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Warren Smith

Percussionist Warren Smith has expertly balanced a successful career as a music educator, studio musician, and performing artist. Warren was active in the 1970s Soho loft scene and cites his participation in M'Boom with Max Roach as one of his most creative accomplishments.

Warren was interviewed in Utica, NY on March 17, 2018 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm very pleased to have with me, in Utica, New York at the Other Side, Warren Smith. And I'm going to start out with an understatement. Warren Smith has done a few diverse things in his career. Is that a fairly true statement?

WS: That's true. I like to keep it a round robin you know.

MR: Uh huh. Has there been one thing out of all the things you've done that has been your favorite?

WS: I would have to say two or three rather.

MR: Okay. You can have two or three.

WS: The year that I left college, in 1957, Harry Partch came to the college and did a residency. And I performed in his ensemble and rehearsed with him for the whole year, and then when that event was finished we put all his stuff in a truck and I drove his truck back up to Ohio, in Yellow Springs or someplace, Ohio, and then brought the memories and the truck back with me. That was probably the first really outstanding experience.

MR: What was your role in that?

WS: I played an instrument called the bass marimba. It was, his octave was not a tempered 12-key octave. His octave had about 43 tones in it. So he had a lot of microtones. But he had built all these instruments himself, and one I remember was a bass marimba. It had four notes. And you had to play it with the handle, with a mallet, the handle was the size of the lower end of a baseball bat, and the ball that hit the instrument was bigger than, it was about the size of a sixteen inch softball. But it was made out of fiber, or some kind — and you hit it, and this one big note, you couldn't hear it at all. It had sixteen vibrations and you could see it vibrating. You couldn't hear it but you could feel the vibrations in your stomach. And there were a lot of things about Harry Partch that I'll never forget you know, but the way that he composed his music and rehearsed us and whatnot was just, that was probably the first real professional challenge in my life, even before I got into the profession, where I was making a living at it.

MR: Did you, at that time, start to think that's one of the things I would like to do. What he's

WS: The performance part of it yes, and the ensemble parts of it and working that hard was, but like the rest of school there were other ambitions that I had. There were other tastes that I had that I couldn't satisfy simply within that one type of music. You know I had grown up around Chicago jazz all my life. My father was a saxophone player and a teacher, had notable students among them: Gene Ammons and Johnny Griffin. And these were kinds of people that I was used to being around and growing up with.

MR: Your father taught those two players?

WS: Yeah. Those were two of the ones he taught.

MR: Wow.

WS: I mean everybody, Charlie Parker came to Chicago and his horn needed fixing, so the first person he came to was my father. And we're sitting there looking at Bird. And all he wanted was to have his horn fixed. But I mean all the saxophone players came there to get their instruments repaired.

MR: You knew who Bird was then?

WS: Who?

MR: You knew who Bird was at that time.

WS: Oh absolutely. Sure. Yeah. Yeah by the time I was ten — well first of all there were musicians coming in and out of the house all the time you know. It was like a musical center. Because literally all the saxophone players came and others came and hung out you know. My mother was a harpist and she taught the harp and performed. All of my uncles and aunts were involved in music on both sides of the family. So it was not unusual to just be associated with musicians. I had made up my mind by the time I was three I was going to be a musician. And you know my ambitions never varied.

MR: And your parents were on your side with that.

WS: Oh yeah. Yeah, I mean not just my parents, the whole family.

MR: Sort of like a New Orleans family, where it's just —

WS: Yes. Yeah my father came from North Carolina, my mother was born outside of Chicago in Maywood, Illinois. And you know, my grandfather had been a chef on the Chicago Northwestern Railroad. So he was used to traveling back and forth from California and whatnot. And I didn't really know my paternal grandfather but my grandmother, my father's mother, still lived in the country so we'd go down there every year and visit with her. She lived to be 103. And that grandfather on my mother's side, he lived to be about 106. And they were active. They were walking around. My grandmother, my father's mother, was bedridden and had a wheelchair. And she said one day my mother was down there and she woke up very early and she saw my grandmother up on her feet puttering around and fixing her bed. And she said, "Grandma Smith, I didn't know you could

walk." She said, "Shit, honey, if these folks knew that I could walk, they'd have me working to death." So it was that kind of humor that just pervaded everything.

MR: I guess. So you were born in 1934?

WS: Yes.

MR: So if you can, maybe if you have a memory of in the early 40s, here you are a kid, do you think jazz music was something that the African-American community embraced and was proud of as something that they had created?

WS: Absolutely. You see Chicago was very, very, probably still is the most segregated big city in the country. And where we lived, on the south side, there were white people around. White neighbors, you know, some people were married to white people. But it was literally all black culturally. And the music was something that everybody was proud of. We had shows where my father and my uncles had to dress up in tuxedos and shine black shoes and whatnot and go to work and come home, and then the next day they'd have to get up and go work in the post office or something like that, whatever they did. But the music was a constant thing. And it was literally a profession that we were all proud of. Nobody was ashamed to say that I'm a musician. You know, I mean it was just part of life.

MR: So your grandmother didn't say, "Now Warren, don't you be going in those blues clubs" or anything.

WS: Well you know we had those cautionary warnings, but I mean it was the fact that we were so exposed to a wide range of people. People coming in town and out of town from other places were rotating through the family, and there were discussions of politics at that early age. I remember discussions about Communism and Socialism, and by 1942 — I remember when President Roosevelt brought us into the war. I remember hearing those things on the radio. We didn't have any television in those days.

MR: Yeah, because you were about six or seven, something like that?

WS: Yeah. Yeah, between those ages. Even before high school you know.

MR: Did you have intentions of getting an academic music career?

WS: I didn't have, you know watching my father and my uncles do these great musical jobs and working in the post office, and I worked in the post office, I spent five or six years from high school through college, and even my first year in New York to survive I worked in the post office. But I went to school, I enrolled in architecture school. I qualified for that and enrolled in that for my first year. And the only courses that I got A's in were the music courses that I took. And I of course took percussion courses and got in the new percussion ensemble which was just starting in the early 1950s that hadn't been done in colleges before. And even at that time the thought of being an architect as a

second job in order to support a music career that I would rather not have it be the post office. So I was going to be an architect. But by my second semester it was pretty obvious that all my A's were in the music courses and all my lower grades were in architecture, which I still love and have an appreciation for. So I switched into music education. And after that first semester my involvement and my teachers convinced me to be a music major. But by the end of five years of switching majors and going through undergraduate school I had decided that I would just get a music teaching degree so that I could remain — and I wound up doing that for 40 years. But I never thought about not being a musician.

MR: Gee Chicago had some wonderful music teachers. Who was that fellow named Walter Dyett?

WS: Captain Walter Dyett, my father played in Captain Dyett's band.

MR: Wow.

WS: And Captain Dyett had a summer concert orchestra, and some of my first orchestral experience other than high school and grade school was playing in Captain Dyett's summer orchestra. And that was a wonderful experience you know. But music was always a constant. We had stacks of old 78 rpm records and we were listening to all kinds of music. We would listen to Debussy and all the classical artists as well as all the jazz music that was coming out then.

MR: Can you remember your first paying gig?

WS: Yeah. Working with my father in the Elks Club. Because the Elks Club would have regular Friday night or Saturday night affair and my father broke me in as the drummer when I was fourteen years old. And as a matter of fact he hired a young baritone saxophone player who turned out to be my age and his name was Laurdine "Pat" Patrick. And Pat Patrick of course went on to be one of Sun Ra's band leaders and he came to New York and we did Broadway shows together and all kinds of things together. And in fact we wound up teaching in the same college together, maybe twenty years after that.

MR: I just think it's so fascinating with yourself, and then you mention Pat Patrick, that you can play Broadway music and something that takes a whole lot of discipline, and then you can be in an environment that is so demanding that you be creative and improvisatory. I just think that's really interesting.

WS: The improvisation you see is a state of mind. You have to kind of be, well you have to assume the attitude of having or exercising the liberty to do that. We all have the liberty but we don't always exercise it. And I mean Charlie Parker came to my house to get his horn fixed, and Gene Ammons and Johnny Griffin were my father's students. So you're listening to them and they come in and, you know Sonny Stitt would come from out of

the discussion was more about the transference from swing into bebop because a lot of the older musicians had an attitude about the beboppers, you know, they thought that a lot of them were not able to play. They hadn't encountered — well Bird of course had that prodigious technique, and Dizzy Gillespie, and quite a few people around, but that was not common. You know a lot of people were just well I can't do this so I'll do that. You know, but I never had any doubt that all of these musics were legitimate. And I had to learn, even from high school Richard Wagner and Strauss and Beethoven and all these things, because when I first started tympani in high school, I started messing around with them. And the teacher saw me so he allowed me to play. And by the time I got to high school that was a regular thing. When I got to college I switched into music so that I could have access to these instruments. And I knew that I was going there, but I didn't know how far it would take me. I never had the confidence of being able to make the kind of living that I saw for myself just as a musician.

MR: Um hum. Just as a performing musician.

WS: Yes.

MR: Yeah. That education could basically help you pay your bills.

WS: Yeah. And that was the main thing. I always said that these jobs financed my musical career. And that's literally what happened. Because when I started teaching school I wound up, the first year I got to New York was 1957 and I immediately went into the school system, because the first thing I did was pass the exam to be a teacher, you know you have to prove that you can sight read and that you could articulate. But it was so crazy. I was being interviewed for my first teaching job in New York City and a young lady from France was trying to get a job teaching French. And they were giving her all kinds of problems because of her French accent. And this was so completely ridiculous to me you know. And see in these days you had to sneak to improvise in the music school. So I would get myself locked in so that I could play around with these instruments and find out how to improvise. But if they caught you doing that they would actually fine you you know. It was like a 25 cent fine or you can't use the practice room for two days, or some such. You know there were all these kinds of disciplines. So all my life I was surreptitiously, you know, doing this on the side. And of course in the summertime I was playing with jazz bands and listening to all these great musicians come through the house and converse. So I knew that's what I wanted to do eventually but all this other stuff — even classical music to a certain extent was the back-up for a livelihood, for a living.

MR: So your daughters learned early on what a gig was.

WS: Oh absolutely.

MR: Right? Dad has a gig tonight.

WS: Yeah that was never even a problem. And in fact it got to the point where the girls that I dated had to understand that music was going to be the first thing. I told my first wife that, "Do you know that music is —" and of course that was bullshit because she wasn't going to have that. And not knowing women at that point I didn't realize that every woman that I encountered after that wasn't going to have that either you know. But you know playing is still first in my heart.

MR: Something you said struck me because when you were talking about sort of the controversy with musicians and probably the audience too, about swing and bebop, that years later I read about the same thing when people talk about free or avante garde jazz, that people would say, "Yeah that's where people go when they can't really play."

WS: Yes.

MR: What's your thought on that?

WS: Well I just ignored it. Because I definitely heard that, all throughout my career. You know? And when I started doing, trying to do things, even, you know you didn't want people to hear you making mistakes even when you practice. And you have to make mistakes when you practice, because you have to overcome those mistakes and form a discipline around them. So it just, well a lot of things. I kept quiet about it pretty much until I was at home, and then I could discuss this with my parents and my relatives, but I thought so many of these rules were just completely ridiculous. So as many of them as I could get away with I just ignored. I never had any respect for the law, as the imperative design for the way you live. Or at least what other people thought it should be. You know, because there were so many things that my teachers taught me throughout grade school and high school that I just did not believe. And I challenged this at home. I remember a high school teacher that, she was a substitute, and she made the statement — I think I was in my junior year of high school, that, "A Negro never contributes at anything to the building of this country." You know? Which I thought was complete bullshit right then. But it encouraged me to study and find out the real history of the people who actually did build this country, which were almost all black because of slavery. You know? And there were other intellectual and artistic things that they were inventing that everybody was benefitting from and imitating that we were not getting credit for.

MR: Nor being taught in the school system.

WS: Yes. I mean the school system was just that way. You know, I never had, I think I saw a substitute black teacher in my maybe third or fourth year of high school — the first black teacher I encountered. And I knew black teachers were out there because we went to the south, and went to all black schools, and in fact DuSable High School where Captain

from were black teachers. And they were playing Broadway shows, they were doing concert work. You know Captain Dyett was conducting a classical orchestra and all this repertoire and stuff, I learned more of that from him than I learned from my own high school.

MR: I see. I want to leap forward a little bit, to make sure we get to a couple of things. One was the studio work you did in New York, and you made a statement in an earlier interview that I read, it might have been referring to either studio work or Broadway shows, that you were in a position where if they needed a qualified black musician I could be called. Was that because there was a movement that we have to start hiring some black musicians?

WS: No. It was not that. It was pure racism. I think so. Because the people at the top were all white. And they were the ones who were hiring, all right? Now a few black musicians that showed a talent that could not be ignored or one that was needed commercially were the ones who were able to make a living playing commercial music shall we say.

MR: Like Milt Hinton?

WS: Like Milt Hinton. Like — oh my memory.

MR: Joe Wilder perhaps?

WS: Who?

MR: Joe Wilder.

WS: Joe Wilder was one of my idols, and he and I were together on staff the first staff job that I had. Or I should say the first television/radio job that I had was at Channel 7 ABC. And they hired me because they had a special show, "The Jimmy Dean Show." And the conductor of that show was someone that I had done a Broadway show with. So he hired me for that show. And that led me to be a staff musician with Channel 7. And the only two other black people in that position were Joe Wilder and Ernie Royal. And of course their talent could not be denied. You know so they were working regularly, they were doing Broadway shows and they were doing all kinds of jobs, anything other than playing with the New York Philharmonic. And that was still closed. In fact one of my high school classmates was the first black man in a major symphony orchestra in New York. His name was Ortiz Walton. And he played bass. He went up, and this was one of the first times that they did this, they put a curtain on the stage so that the judges could not see who the applicant was. And he played the bass and he played a Mozart violin concerto on the contrabass violin. This was a guy I went to grade school and high school with. He was a year ahead of me. And he had two brothers, his older brother played tympani, which was my ambition. I took his place when he graduated from high school. And he had a younger brother who played cello. And both of them wound up, I know the younger

Symphony, through this means. You know he auditioned behind the curtain. I mean he was playing jazz gigs in high school. You know, like at fifteen and sixteen. He was going into Chicago. We lived out in Maywood, Illinois, which was twenty miles out. He was going in there to play gigs and things. And, you know, I didn't know he was going to take this music that far, but by the time I got to the Tanglewood School in my last year of college, he was already in the Boston Symphony. So that gave me an ambition that perhaps I could do this. And I wound up subbing in some of these orchestras. But that was something, I didn't want to be locked in just playing classical music, for one thing.

MR: So in the height of your studio work can you maybe recall a typical day where you might do more than one date, and just the logistics of how that worked and the variety of music?

WS: You know with this connection into that Channel 7 job, which I got because of a — what was it, a television show or something that I did that led me in to all that, it got me hired for that. There were a lot of opportunities to do — I'm sorry, restate that question again.

MR: Oh, well I just wanted to hear about your memory of a typical day in the studio scene.

WS: Oh yes. Now I fell into a pattern as a result of the contacts inside the studio music work and all of the other jobs that I had where a typical week, say maybe forty weeks out of the year, because leading up to Easter everything was dull. And it broke down after Easter, through the summer and in the fall, then everything got busy again. But on a typical say fall through the winter into the spring I might be called for a record date at ten o'clock in the morning 'til one, and then maybe one from two to five, and then maybe have to do a Broadway show at night, or maybe do a third. And I was one of the lesser people. You know some of these guys worked four or five record dates in a day. And five days a week. And I fell into that pattern and that got to be worrisome because you were never home, I was driving out to Long Island to go home, and my kids would only see me on the weekends, that kind of stuff, because I'd usually have to leave as they were going to school. And it got where my wife, God bless her, was just a hero, and just held up the family while I — and, all right, third marriage now, the same thing is still happening. This woman — if I didn't have a good back-up woman, I wouldn't have been able to do a lot of this, and I wound up with five daughters. Four by my first wife and one by my second wife. And of course they've all been through college and done their stuff, and I've got five out my ten grandchildren finished college. So I can't complain about how it turned out. But it was a very rigorous thing. I probably wouldn't have changed if I'd had the choice. Because some of those record dates that we did were just amazing. Some of them were things that I didn't like to do so much but those memories fade very fast.

MR: Yes. The down gigs. Can you name a few things that you've played on that are fairly well known?

WS: I remember a little guy came from Ireland and did something called "Astral Weeks." What was this guy's name? Tell me his name.

MR: His name, the guy who did — Van Morrison.

WS: And he was such a shy little guy. And he had this big bag of vegetable leaf that he was rolling into these vegetable cigarettes. I mean the smell was not marijuana, but he was doing this, and he would hardly come out of the booth, he would hardly speak to us, but you know he just brought these tunes out and we just played them. I think that whole, what was the big hit out of that "Astral Weeks" album?

MR: "Moondance?"

WS: "Moondance."

MR: That's you on "Moondance?"

WS: Yeah, yeah, yeah, yeah. We did all these things in maybe like two sessions. And the main problem, it was not him, it wasn't the music, the music was, you know we had Connie Kay playing drums and maybe George Duvivier playing — you know all these masters. I was honored to be among their company. But he was — no it was Richard Davis was the bass player. But he was probably scared to death of all of us. And he very seldom even communicated other than well this is the next song I'm going to do. Very shy and kind of reticent to express himself. But he didn't have any trouble singing the songs. He certainly knew his material.

MR: What shape was the music in? Was it chord charts? Do you know?

WS: Well see a lot of the things were just lead sheets with the chord changes on them. Occasionally there were certain things that were arranged. If he had an arranger there were certain lines we'd have to play. I was usually playing percussion. Because I didn't have a reputation at all then as a drummer. And I wasn't a very good drummer, because I had been trained as a percussionist. I mean I could play drums, but not to compete with the people who were playing in New York. You know, so I got a chance, even that was an education for me to see how these great drummers were actually handling things. You know so I was always being educated by my surroundings. You know. But Van was very shy, but we did all this stuff in like two days I think. Like maybe four recording sessions, about twelve hours of work altogether.

MR: I just have this picture of you telling your grandkids, "You hear that song? I'm playing on that." "Sure, Grandpa."

WS: That would happen every now and then. When — my kids too because they know pretty much about my career but I have five daughters. Neither of them would marry a musician, ever. Which is amusing to me. But they can see how sporadic that kind of lifestyle could be, and they all married men, I mean I'm proud of all my sons-in-laws,

about that, was to give them the judgement to choose a mate that would not be abusive or was not an evil person basically. And they all made me proud in their choices. They've stayed with their spouses, each one of them. And I actually have now five great-grandchildren.

MR: Wow. You know bless your heart. You're 83 now?

WS: Yeah. I'll be 84 in May.

MR: Okay here you are basically on a road trip with a U-Haul trailer behind the car and you're doing your thing. And I salute you for that. Which sort of brings me to, I want to talk about this music that you play and have played over the years with Sam Rivers and all this. And I don't know, do you like or tolerate the word "free" as in free jazz? Because a lot of times the musicians who are playing the music aren't people that named it. Or label it.

WS: That's true. And I have received, when I was working in the studio I used to be criticized by the studio musicians for that other kind of music that I was involved in you know. Not so much the straight legitimate jazz music and so forth, but the free music that I was — because I got attracted to that very early. And one of the reasons I got attracted to that was because in school, primarily in college, when I started studying percussion with Paul William Price at the University of Illinois, I was introduced to people like Harry Partch and John Cage and all these other really out composers that were fragmented, and I was you know, I went to Tanglewood one year and Lukas Foss was there, and Bernstein was the conductor. And of course getting into — even the people in show business, all of them didn't respect the pure jazz players. And the pure jazz players didn't think that the people who were playing this straight legitimate music were adequate improvisers. So there was a wall between the two and I'm bouncing back and forth between these walls being criticized by both sides. Plus the fact that because I had a family I was teaching school pretty much on a regular basis. I don't know how, but I was working literally like three jobs for twenty-five or thirty years.

MR: You make me tired just thinking about it.

WS: Well I think tired is a mindset. I mean I've worked all my life, I was going to school, working at the post office and paper routes, and anything else. Because we didn't have a lot of money, so I worked my way, I worked for my meals by busing dishes, sometimes being a short order cook and things like that, all through college. Even when I went to graduate school I wound up at Manhattan School of Music running the cafeteria. That helped pay for my scholarship. You know, but the music was there so I didn't mind it.

MR: So if we can use the term free jazz for a while, in your mind, what is it free of?

WS: I think allowing your mind to guide you in a performance that is not pre-scripted. All

they can't play anything. And then I know other people that are noodling all the time — well I was a notorious noodler, not I mean I wasn't a noodler because I'm sitting in the classroom and the teacher is talking, and I mean even today, I'll be lying in bed and my feet are going — my wife says Whap! Oh. I could never break that habit from grade school, I got into trouble for making noise that disturbed the teacher. So in 84 years I haven't lost that somehow. Every time my mind wanders and I'm relaxing, you know, some idea, and sometimes I have to stop and write it down so that I can turn it into a piece of music. But the fact that I have this free flow of ideas going all the time, I think that's what your imagination stems from and I think that — I call this creative musicians. That is musicians who don't need an outside stimulus to produce their musical thoughts.

MR: Outside stimulus meaning someone else has written down what they want you to do, either real specifically or just in a framework.

WS: Yeah. Yeah. Well see now even people like John Cage for instance, definitely had a framework. But he wanted you to infuse your ideas into that framework. And I remember oh man, it was really weird. We were in the University of Illinois and Cage was there one day. And you know you're playing all this weird music, and some of it was written you know but he'd tell you to do something, and I did something unusual and I'm looking at him down there at his seat. And I did it. And he like had an orgasm, like that, some brief ecstatic feeling of something unexpected that happened within his music because listening to him talk, he wanted us to infuse those ideas to enhance his music. You know. He had situations he told us where people would get up and walk out and slam their seat down, and that was part of his music. It was his intention to stimulate those kinds of reactions. In other words, my music is reaching you whether you like it or not you know. But I took that for myself. And it made me able to accept people not understanding what I was trying to write or form as musical. Because I was hearing some things that other people weren't. And of course other people were doing the same thing.

MR: So I've been thinking about this, I watched a few things on YouTube that you were on, and then some other things that Joseph Daley had done. I was trying to surmise if listening to avante garde or free or extremely creative music is easier for people who don't know how music works? Because I think I have a bad habit of trying to compartmentalize things if I'm listening to something, and I'm listening — okay I've got the groove or I can hear the key, I can hear the root. And then if music comes along that it's not there, I may have trouble with it. I'm not sure that was a question.

WS: No, I understand that inquiry because you have to get over I guess a feeling of rejection of the ideas that you present, the fear of that. You know what I mean? Because if you only want to please people then you are limited by what would please them. But

expect and it will enlarge their audience. I remember doing something once where I had a prescripted motif and it went something [scats] you know, just that. And I'd point to another musician and he'd do that you know, in his own fashion, and another one, she'd do that or he'd, you know. And it went around. And I said, "Let me try something." I'm on the stage and I got the whole band collectively to do it [scats]. And then I turned around to the audience and the audience sang it back. And I said oh. So the fact that you can actually involve the audience in yourself — they don't have to actually have been familiar with the material. But if they can hear it they will meet you halfway.

MR: Have you ever had a circumstance where you try to instruct the audience on how to listen to what they're about to hear? Instruct is not really what I mean. Give them an entry point.

WS: I think you do that before the presentation. In your preparation for the presentation if you do that at all you know. Some people have a strong enough ego where they don't care whether you like it or not, this is what I do and, you know. I mean I really try to reach an audience with my own compositions or performance in a way. But I don't let it restrict what I present to them. And sometimes things come up that I don't expect to understand myself you know. Sometimes something can happen in an audience that makes you respond to it, you know, in some way. And the thing that I liked about free music was that it gives you the room to do that you know, where you don't know what's going to happen at some point. But I feel that the music that interests me most is the music that gives me some surprises. Because I'm so used to hearing consonant chords and resolutions and things like this. And sometimes you want music just like a decent play, that leaves you up in the air and makes you resolve it yourself, you know, maybe mentally.

MR: I was going to ask you, in some cases, how do you know when to end a piece of music that is basically being spontaneously created.

WS: You have to develop a judgement for that. You have to develop that judgement over a period of time. And I feel now at this stage in my life, you know, after like 56 years of presentation, that I can tell when an audience might be bored. I can see restlessness, I can see people moving instead of everybody like this. And you get to the point where you can actually from the stage almost orchestrate the audience reaction you know. And if you have that big of an insight, and experience gives you that.

MR: Good answer. You said this thing I saw, that you like exaggeration.

WS: Who?

MR: You said you like exaggeration.

WS: Oh absolutely, yes.

WS: Yes, in particular volume. You know volume can go both ways. You can, you know, exaggerate emotion and play a very quiet sound you know. Or you can start something very soft and let it expand itself so it comes up. Now these are shapes you understand. But I think it's more akin to like a visual artist. You know because you can paint these pictures in the air and the audience looks at them and responds in the fashion that eventually you can almost anticipate what the audience is going to do. Or you can say I won't do that 'cause I don't think that's going to be responded to well. So that might be my only restriction at this point.

MR: I see. Wow. You've got a lot of food for thought here. How do you, you mentioned before that out of the blue you might start doing some physical motion and you've got to write that down. Now that could be a kernel for a composition —

WS: Yes.

MR: And then do you assign like an instrument or something in your head to that — maybe the marimba should be doing this, and you start orchestrating it?

WS: It depends on my interpretation of the quality of the sound that I want to reproduce or that I want to hear reproduced. There are certain fat sounds like from a bass violin that you don't get from anything else. And percussion in particular has these qualities. You know a bass drum is the lowest sound in the orchestra. And you can hit it very softly or you can marry it with a high sound, like a cymbal or a flute or something very high pitched and get that bass, and it gives it a body that it doesn't have. It like allows one sound to ride on the other. And everybody feels that. I was just talking to somebody, I mentioned Harry Partch before. He had an instrument called the bass marimba. And it had only four keys on it. And the mallet was the handle was like the lower end of a baseball bat and the head was like a soft, sixteen inch softball. And you hit this instrument, this particular bar, and you could see these sixteen vibrations. Physically you could see them. But you couldn't hear it. But you could feel all sixteen vibrations in your stomach you know. And when you get sensitive to things like that, the certain sounds that are above your hearing capacity, but you feel something, you can maybe feel it in your teeth, you can feel it in. We all experience this in some way, you know a car screeches and there is an anticipation — what's going to happen, is there going to be a bang? All these things are like we're conditioned to this. So I try to take advantage of previous conditioning and try to manipulate that so it stimulates the reaction that I want from an audience.

MR: Wow. You've worked with some memorable musicians and artists over the years. And I believe you said you were talking about Max Roach. And he had an ego you said.

WS: Oh man, that was an education in itself. I mean here's a person who had a variation from piano to quadruple forte, even emotionally. You know I mean he could be the most

see him gritting his teeth and chewing his jaws and you could see where something was about to implode and he could erupt. You know he and I, I mean I guess maybe I'm an amateur psychologist. I like to read people. And I usually can avoid problems by anticipating somebody's emotions. But I remember a couple of times he and I got into shouting matches about something. And something in me would never let me back down. You know, and we wound up being able to get along really well with each other because of that. But I mean now here's a musical genius but he was open, but he was also emotionally open and that could go either way you know what I mean? Being emotionally open he is vulnerable. So certain things could excite him, you know, or make him angry, and he might react. If he's got the drumset he can react with that. But if the drumset is not there you might be a percussion instrument. But I mean he was, the first music that I heard I was watching Max Roach and listening to him.

MR: In Chicago?

WS: Yeah. Oh we had his records you know. I mean he was like a teenager himself when I first heard him, when he first started playing all these things. But the first time I heard him — I'll show you how sensitive he was — I went to a club in Chicago called the Beehive. And a friend of mine was there. He was working with Clifford Brown. And we went and heard him and Clifford was watching the audience when he wasn't — Max was playing, and Max was playing kind of loud. And this friend of mine, I'm watching the stage all the time. And he says, "Man, Max Roach is playing too loud." And Clifford read his lips. And he turned around and I said oh shit, something's gonna — he turned around and he whispered something in Max's ear, and Max diminished his volume. He responded to it. He had that kind of respect for Clifford Brown. He wouldn't have accepted that from me necessarily, or from another audience member. But this is the kind of nuances that you deal with, with an artist of this capability and breadth of expression I guess you know. It could go any way. But it's a great lesson to observe.

MR: I love this comment you made about when you had, it might have been M'Boom that you were talking about or some of the other large ensembles, but you said something about, "Everyone has a different idea of where the beat is at." And I can imagine that's got to be a little tricky.

WS: Well that was because see there's a certain ego about drummers. And they all have to be right when they're in the position of propelling a band. You know the drummer has to be the most constant figure because everybody else can match that. It's the most audible sound and everybody can feel that vibration so they can lock in to that. But when you have six or seven drummers who are all, I mean all these guys were great musicians, you know, Max had chosen us from his observations and experience with us. Not every one

that we all had so much respect for Max Roach that we just let him lead everything. But when we started presenting our own music, and you might have to criticize Max Roach for something, then you wonder how that's going to go. But see he was broad enough where he could accept that you know. Now not all leaders can accept criticism of themselves for whatever they do. So they're locked in a position where if they're going over a cliff they're gone. You know. And if you don't like it just get off the cliff. I mean just get off of their train. But it varies with different people. Some band leaders you can't tell them a God damn thing. And their music's going to stay locked right where it is. There are others like Gil Evans, I'll put Max in that, Duke Ellington was definitely in that category. He could tolerate any kind of crazy behavior because he knew what he wanted out of those musicians. And I think that's a very important thing. It's shaped my attitude as a band leader, that I can be a lot more tolerant when things don't go exactly the way I prescribe because sometimes those ideas can improve your concept, or give you something that you hadn't thought of before. So it balances out. But you have to have an open mind.

MR: To accept that, that someone heard something that you hadn't written or proscribed.

WS: Yes. Especially something that you write and it's got to be correct and it's got to be this and that. And it's so prevalent. I did a lot of classical music. I did a lot of symphonies and contemporary music in particular where everything is just so locked in you know. But if you took the piece of paper away from me, or the musical representation that said play an idea, I could do that. There are some people that are so locked in to that, that when you take it away from them there is silence. What am I supposed to do now? And I think that that's a detriment to musical artistry.

MR: Yeah. Well unlimited choices can sometimes be scary.

WS: Oh yeah, yeah. I mean it's something that's a chance. But getting out of bed every morning is a chance. So I have lived with chance all my life. It's never been, "Oh I'm going to have a million dollars today" and tad at, tad at, tad at. Every day. But see that's what keeps life interesting for me.

MR: Did you ever have an association with Sun Ra?

WS: Yes. Yes, yes, yes. Sun Ra was from Chicago. And a lot of my friends still play with Sun Ra. Some of my students, in fact his concert master was a student of mine, Knoel Scott. I had him for four years at State University of New York in Old Westbury. In fact Sun Ra was playing in my studio. He was rehearsing there. And a lot of these guys joined his band just because they hung out at my studio and were around when he was rehearsing. He said, "Well I don't have a flute player today. Oh you play the flute? Get on in here." And he was just so open and so great you know. But see Sun Ra is also a band leader

most — well I won't say most, but a lot of his musicians, he always had a big open house, would actually wind up living there with him. And you know, having family and whatnot I could never devote that kind of outside, time outside of my family. But I remember the last time I played with Sun Ra he was working at a club down in Greenwich Village called the Bottom Line. And the club is not there anymore. I mean the building is there but the club is different. And at one point he had us all marching around the club and around the exterior of the bandstand and singing [chants] Shoulder to shoulder/hand to hand/learn to march like a man. You know it was a nice chant and had a rhythm to it, and everybody's marching around and the audience is going with us. And it got to be time for me to leave because I've got to get up and go teach the next morning. And you know Sun Ra doesn't have any concept of time other than his own ideas. So the last time around the back of the bandstand I just grabbed my drumsticks off the drum and so into "March Like a Man" I marched right out the door and went on home you know. He never called me again after that. But I mean it was great because he was so open and accepting of anything that a lot of people would do. And he got a lot of people stimulated enough that they brought some ideas out of themselves that they didn't know that they had. And that's probably the most unique part of Sun Ra's orchestra. But to be able to do that on a regular basis and have people that you depend on and count on, you have to have control of those people. And I'm not the kind of person who can accept that kind of control. So a lot of those bands I either didn't stay in very long or I had a very short tenure with.

MR: I sometimes wonder how he and other people who are doing that kind of thing could just survive economically.

WS: You know there's a Buddhist theory: Your ambition — I think it's ambition is not the word, but your choice of life is to achieve a state where you have a lack of want. Okay? Now a lack of want is knowing when you reach the point of achieving what you need and then being able to accept that as a level of your lifestyle you know. So that means you lose the ambition of acquisition. I've got to have more money. Because these things are limitless in their appetite. And that attitude — I've seen so many people just completely lose themselves just in the quest for that constant acquisition of more and more and more. Where they don't even enjoy what they have now. You know? And we've elected that. I'll say no more than that. But it's like people who don't know when they are happy, or aren't able to enjoy seeing your child learn how to walk or your wife be happy that you did something, you know, appreciative. And they lose that. So I don't ever want to get to that point.

MR: You seem to be an astute observer, and I wonder what you think of what the state of our

WS: I have seen presidents from Franklin Delano Roosevelt. And each succeeding one. And Roosevelt I liked a lot. I liked John F. Kennedy a lot. And I am absolutely crazy about Barack Obama. I thought he was the closest to my heart that ever got elected. But of those three, those are the only three that I favored. I didn't even favor Kennedy as my favorite candidate at that time. There was somebody else — Adlai Stevenson was in that race and I thought Adlai Stevenson would have been a more appropriate choice. But Obama was the first one that I — you know when I first saw him I called up my cousins in Chicago and I said, "What do you think about this guy?" And they all gave him a very good rating. And then I started watching and he never disappointed me. I mean you know there were things he was forced into that had to be done, but I understand that as a black person. I understand that as a president, you know, I've been a chairman or a president of a fraternity or a club or whatever. And there are things that you have to do that you may not want to do or your mind isn't in, but you have to do that for the good of the organization of whatever it is. You know, so nobody is perfect. But the rest of these people, I have not been in their corner. I have not voted for them. And they yet were able to be presidents. I have never found a Republican that I could vote for since I've been of voting age. But other than that I've still been disappointed for the most part.

MR: Okay. Are you optimistic?

WS: Yeah. I'm optimistic that I'll be able to hold my breath for three more years. And then we'll see what happens. But I'm not going to be completely despondent if another poor choice gets in. Because I've seen poor choices get in and I've lived through them you know. It just means that there are areas where things might be a little bit more difficult for me, but temporarily you know. So you know, I feel good about life.

MR: I'll just wrap up with you are doing a road trip here with the trio of Joseph Daley and Scott Robinson, who by the way if you recall I said don't say anything bad about us. But they're not here. But do you have a sense of what you'd like people to take away from your performance tonight?

WS: Last night we played. This is only the second concert on the tour. The first one, you know, we usually get a — but people came up to me on two or three occasions and said, "I felt you." And if I can get that kind of a reaction then I'm happy. You know they could see that I was doing something that was reaching out and that they could grab and pull back on. And I can't ask for any more than that.

MR: Yeah 'cause that's sort of open ended too.

WS: Yeah.

MR: I mean, "I felt you" and they didn't say it was the greatest thing I ever heard, or it could be any kind of reaction.

WS: Yeah. I mean how much have you heard? You know you have to go into all that. But when somebody comes up and expresses a personal reaction from your output then okay I've done my job.

MR: Excellent. Anything else that you would have a chance to say that you would offer?

WS: Well I could only say that I feel like I've been blessed with a great family, from my upbringing, the knowledge that they gave me. I've been married three times and all three times were people that I love. My second wife is still alive and we have a child. We're not together but it's not that there's any tension. You know and my third wife has been great for twenty years, and I can't, you know, I'm happy. I'll be ready to go when it's time.

MR: Okay. You were summarizing your career at one point and you said, "I was lucky but I had to work my ass off."

WS: Oh absolutely, yeah. And I'll tell you something. I was lucky that I had to work my ass off because that put me where I am you know. That gave me the strength and the foundation to do what I'm trying to do. So you know, nothing is wasted.

MR: Well congratulations on your prodigious career and I hope the weather works out for your tour, and you get to see some scenery on the way.

WS: All right

MR: Okay.

WS: Thank you, Monk.

MR: Thank you very much.